like the goal I scored at school. I feel like I'm not sure where it has come from but use all my power to make it seem like this is something I do every day, business as usual. Jadeja is in again and this time I'm on my knees, reverse-sweeping square. This one's even better. Shami runs in – angrier by the treatment – and bowls short. It sits up nicely, the pitch not quick enough to rush me, and for a second I'm the image of Boris Becker, just like the way I used to re-enact at home with the settee in front of the TV, double-handedly smashing it down the line.

I'm suddenly flicking the ball off my hips and timing it perfectly for four, the kind of shots that tempt fielders to chase all the way to the boundary, but they never reach. When I pass my best Test score, Joe Root walks up to me, beaming, patting me on the shoulder, telling me to keep going. I begin to feel like he's enjoying watching me more than batting himself. By the time Shami's running in to bowl to me, we have put on a hundred for the last wicket, 47 of them mine. I've a sixth sense he's going to drop it short again, so I charge down the wicket, reach the ball from outside my eyeline on the off side and carve it in the opposite direction, momentarily losing hold of the bat handle, and watch the ball race over the boundary for four.

I have 50 in a Test match – one more than I managed in that 50 overs grind for Burnley. The crowd is all on their feet and Joe is running towards me, laughing, hugging me as I let a smile finally show itself on my face. The toil with the ball – all of the running in and constant physical exertion that I had put in for England – finally repaying me with one afternoon where I know what it feels like to be a genuine Test match batter. I am in the land of fantasy again, feeling that sense of transcendence that Test cricket gives you, allowing you to find something else completely in you that you didn't know you had.

It's turned into a Zen-like state by the time I'm continuing to play shots. We've forgotten about the protecting of the strike between us, just two batters playing shots, reading the game, acting on pure instinct, caught up in a moment that once set in motion has no friction or tension in it at all, just pure enjoyment. I'm skipping down the pitch and hitting the ball down the ground to level the scores. I've been at the wicket now for longer than any number 11 in the history of Test cricket. We both hold the record for the highest tenth wicket partnership in Test match history. There are shots I